

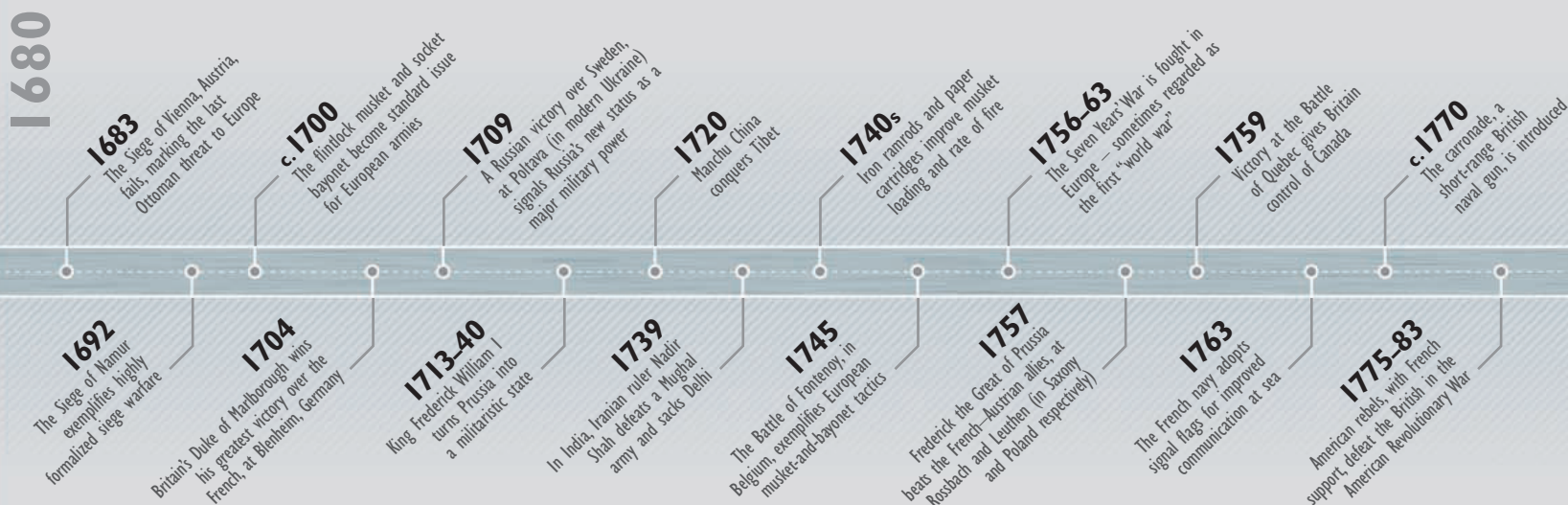
INTRODUCTION

From the late 17th to the early 19th centuries, there were few dramatic changes in military technology. The basic infantry weapon was the flintlock musket with bayonet attached; artillery consisted of smoothbore muzzle-loading cannon. However, the nature of warfare developed in organization, ideology, strategy, and tactics.

Eighteenth-century European states maintained permanent armies commanded by officers, with regiments and formal hierarchies of rank. Infantry were uniformed and issued with standard equipment, harshly disciplined, and drilled to march and fight in formation with automatic obedience. Cavalry performed a variety of roles, from reconnaissance to charges or pursuit of the enemy, while field artillery was also now a key part of armies. At sea, a ship of the line might mount 70–130 cannon in broadside. Thus, non-European states, such as Ottoman Turkey or Indian princedoms, found themselves at a military disadvantage.

From the second half of the 18th century, a new spirit infused European warfare, related to the currents of revolution that swept America in the 1770s, and France from 1789. Although the War of Independence, waged by America against Britain, was fought mostly by conventional armies, irregular troops with rifles showed their effectiveness. This encouraged European armies to make better use of skirmishers as an adjunct to their line infantry, and to arm some of their forces with rifles. In 1793, the French revolutionary government created a mass national army, based on the idea that men should fight due to patriotic enthusiasm, rather than fear of punishment. After rising to power in 1799, Napoleon Bonaparte reorganized the French army into a unified force of four corps, each capable of independent operations. Like the British Royal Navy's Admiral Nelson, at sea Napoleon favoured an offensive strategy and aggressive tactics. By 1815, European armies had grown to unprecedented size and states had shown an ability to mobilize vast resources for victory in war.

KEY DATES



THE SACK OF MAGDEBURG — 1631



THE SIEGE OF NAMUR — 1692



THE BATTLE OF YORKTOWN — 1781

